Philosophy · Epistemology · Scepticism

Scepticism and Knowledge: Workbook

Consolidation tasks to work through alongside the slideshow

This workbook follows the slideshow in order. Each task tells you which slides help. Work through it in class or at home; if you missed a lesson, the slide numbers show you where to catch up.

Every task has a sentence starter or a word bank. Use them as much as you need. Tick the checklist at the end of each part when you feel confident.

In this workbook

1. What scepticism is (slides 2–3)
2. Humean scepticism (slides 4–5)
3. Cartesian scepticism (slides 6–7)
4. Agrippa's trilemma (slide 8)
5. Foundationalism, coherentism, infinitism (slides 9–14)
6. Why study scepticism? (slide 15)
7. Exam-style practice
8. Glossary self-test and final checklist

Part 01 What scepticism is

Task 1.1 Ordinary or philosophical? (slide 2)

Key idea Ordinary scepticism doubts things we would happily admit we don't know. Philosophical scepticism doubts things we normally think we DO know.

Do this: Tick one column for each claim. Then write one more example of each in the empty rows.

Claim	Ordinary	Philosophical
"I don't know whether there is an even number of stars in the Milky Way."		
"I don't know that the sun will rise tomorrow."		
"I don't know how many grains of sand are on Brighton beach."		

"I don't know that I have hands."		
"I don't know what my friend had for breakfast in 2019."		
My example:		
My example:		

Task 1.2 Complete the definition (slide 2)

Do this: Fill the gaps using the word bank. One word is not needed.

Word bank

belief · disbelief · suspension of judgement · justified · certainty

There are three doxastic attitudes: _____, _____ and _____. Philosophical scepticism says that, for a whole field of claims, the only _____ attitude is suspension of judgement.

Task 1.3 How far does the doubt reach? (slide 3)

Do this: Complete the table. Use "local" or "global" in the last column.

Form	What it doubts	Local or global?
Humean		
Cartesian		
Pyrrhonian		

Task 1.4 Think deeper

The Pyrrhonian suspends judgement about everything, even about scepticism itself. Is that self-refuting? Explain in two or three sentences.

I think it is / is not self-refuting because...

Checklist

- ☐ I can explain ordinary vs philosophical scepticism with an example of each.
- ☐ I can name the three doxastic attitudes.
- ☐ I can explain the difference between local and global scepticism.

Part 02 Humean scepticism

Task 2.1 Put the argument in order (slide 4)

Do this: The steps of Hume's argument are jumbled. Number them 1–5 in the boxes.

Step	Order
So we cannot know PUN, and we have no inductive knowledge.	
Induction depends on the Principle of the Uniformity of Nature (PUN).	
An inductive argument for PUN would assume PUN, so it is circular.	
We could know PUN only by deduction or by induction.	
Deduction only gives necessary truths, and PUN is not necessary.	

Task 2.2 Explain the circle (slide 4)

Explain, in your own words, why we cannot use induction to prove that induction works. Use the sunrise example.

Every morning so far the sun has... So I expect... But this only works if...

Task 2.3 Match the response (slide 5)

Do this: Draw a line, or write the letter, to match each thinker to their response.

Thinker	Letter	Response
Van Cleve		A We can know PUN a priori, without experience.
Kant		B We can live without inductive knowledge.
Popper		C The circularity is harmless.

Task 2.4 Judge it

Which response to Hume is strongest? Give one reason for it and one problem with it.

The strongest response is... because... However, one problem is...

Checklist

- ☐ I can explain what PUN is.
- ☐ I can set out Hume's argument in steps.
- ☐ I can explain one confrontational and one concessive response.

Part 03 Cartesian scepticism

Task 3.1 Build the argument (slide 6)

Do this: Complete the argument. h = "I have hands". SH = "I am being deceived by an evil demon".

Premise	Write it out
CP1	If I am justified in believing h, then...

CP2	I am not justified in...
Conclusion	Therefore...

Which principle does CP1 come from? Define it in one sentence.

Task 3.2 Dretske's zebras (slide 7)

Explain how the zebra case is meant to show that the Closure Principle fails.

At the zoo I know... This means they are not... But my evidence...

Now give the reply: why might the zebra case NOT defeat closure?

The case only works if closure needs...

Task 3.3 Responses at a glance (slide 7)

Do this: Complete the table. Strength first, then weakness.

Response	What it claims	One strength	One weakness

Nozick: sensitivity			
Williamson: evidence is knowledge			
Contextualism			

Key idea Helpful hint for the last box: the lemonade case is a problem for sensitivity; contextualism needs a separate argument that we have even minimal justification.

Checklist

- ☐ I can define a sceptical hypothesis.
- ☐ I can set out CP1, CP2 and the conclusion.
- ☐ I can explain and evaluate at least two responses.

Task 3.4 Invent a sceptical hypothesis

Make up your own sceptical hypothesis (not the evil demon or the brain in a vat). Explain why you could not tell it apart from real life.

My scenario is... I could not tell the difference because...

Part 04 Agrippa's trilemma

Task 4.1 The three modes (slide 8)

Do this: Someone claims "The sun will rise tomorrow." A Pyrrhonian keeps asking "Why?". Explain what happens in each case.

If the chain of reasons...	Mode	Why the sceptic is not satisfied
stops with no reason	Hypothesis	
loops back on itself	Circularity	
goes on for ever	Infinite regress	

Task 4.2 Which premise does each theory reject? (slide 8)

Do this: Write the premise number (2, 3 or 5) next to each theory.

Theory	Premise rejected	In one line: how it escapes
Foundationalism		
Coherentism		
Infinitism		

Checklist

- ☐ I can explain the three modes of Agrippa.
- ☐ I can link each theory to the premise it rejects.

Task 4.3 Write the dialogue (slide 8)

Write a short conversation between a "dogmatist" and a Pyrrhonian sceptic. The dogmatist makes a claim; the sceptic keeps asking "Why?". Show all three modes appearing.

Dogmatist: I know that... Sceptic: Why do you believe that? Dogmatist: Because...

Part 05 Three replies to the trilemma

Task 5.1 Compare the three theories (slides 9–14)

Do this: Fill in every box. Keep each answer short: one or two lines.

	Foundationalism	Coherentism	Infinitism
Image from the slide	Building on foundations	Web	Endless chain
Main claim			

Strength			
Main problem			
Thinker linked to it			

Task 5.2 Traditional or moderate? (slide 9)

Do this: Write T (traditional) or M (moderate) for each basic belief.

Belief	T or M
"There is a tomato in front of me."	
"I am having a tomato-like experience."	
"It seems to me that I have hands."	
"I have hands."	

Task 5.3 The isolation objection (slide 12)

Explain the isolation objection using the reading/swimming example. Then say whether you think the coherentist reply works.

Imagine you are reading and I am swimming. If we swapped... This shows that...

Task 5.4 Finite minds (slide 14)

Nobody has infinitely many beliefs. How does the infinitist reply? Is the reply convincing?

The infinitist says we only need... This is / is not convincing because...

Checklist

- ☐ I can explain each theory in one sentence.
- ☐ I can give a strength and a problem for each.
- ☐ I can explain the isolation objection.

Part 06 Why study scepticism?

Task 6.1 Reflect (slide 15)

Almost no philosopher thinks scepticism is true. Give two reasons it is still worth studying.

1.

2.

Task 6.2 Back to the start (slides 1 and 15)

At the start you named something you were certain of. Does it survive the evil demon? Does it survive the trilemma?

My certainty was... It does / does not survive the evil demon because...

Part 07 Exam-style practice

Key idea These questions are written in the style of AQA A-level Philosophy epistemology questions. Check the current specification and mark scheme for exact wording and marks.

Question 1 Explain (5 marks)

Explain how Agrippa's trilemma challenges the claim that we have justified beliefs.

Plan it

1. State the claim being challenged.
2. Give the three options for any chain of reasons.
3. Say why each option fails, according to the sceptic.
4. Conclude: so no belief is justified.

Question 2 Essay

"Scepticism cannot be refuted, so it shows that we have no knowledge." Evaluate this view.

Essay frame

Introduction: define philosophical scepticism and state your line of argument.

Paragraph 1: the strongest sceptical argument (Cartesian or Agrippa). Explain it, then respond.

Paragraph 2: a response that weakens it (e.g. foundationalism, Williamson, contextualism). Strengths first, then problems.

Paragraph 3: a second response, or the counter-argument that the sceptic still wins.

Conclusion: answer the question directly. Does failing to refute scepticism mean we lack knowledge?

Key idea Useful link phrases: “The sceptic would reply that…”, “This is convincing because…”, “However, this response faces the problem that…”, “On balance…”.

Part 08

Glossary self-test

Task 8.1 Write the definition

Do this: Cover the glossary slide. Define each term, then check and correct in a different colour.

Term	My definition
Suspension of judgement	
Local scepticism	
Global scepticism	
Principle of the Uniformity of Nature	

Sceptical hypothesis	
Closure Principle	
Contextualism	
Agrippa's trilemma	
Basic belief	
Isolation objection	

Final checklist

Do this: Tick what you can do. Circle anything you want to go over again.

- ☐ Explain ordinary vs philosophical, and local vs global scepticism.
- ☐ Explain and evaluate Humean scepticism.
- ☐ Explain and evaluate Cartesian scepticism.
- ☐ Set out Agrippa's trilemma.
- ☐ Explain and evaluate foundationalism, coherentism and infinitism.
- ☐ Explain why scepticism matters even if few believe it.